

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Chigorin, Albin, Baltic, and Marshall Defenses

A reliable answer to Black's independent second-move defenses

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

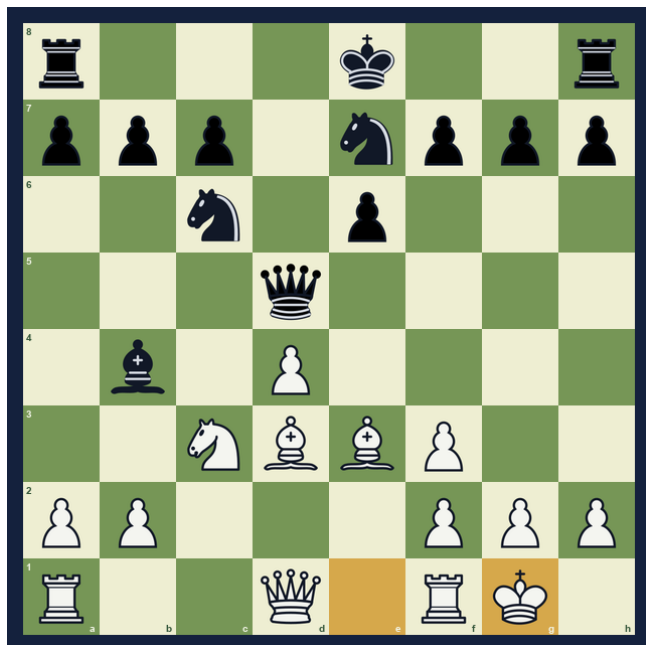
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
1...d5 SIDELINES	20

01. Chigorin Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Be3 and Nc3 to attack the queen naturally.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and prepares active exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

01. Decision Framework

Chigorin Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.
PIECE JOB	The doubled f-pawns give White open lines and bishop activity, so pieces should use those assets rather than defend appearances.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active minor pieces when the bishop pair and open files remain; avoid exchanges that leave only the doubled pawns.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use bishops and open files to create threats, then simplify only after Black's activity has been neutralized. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.

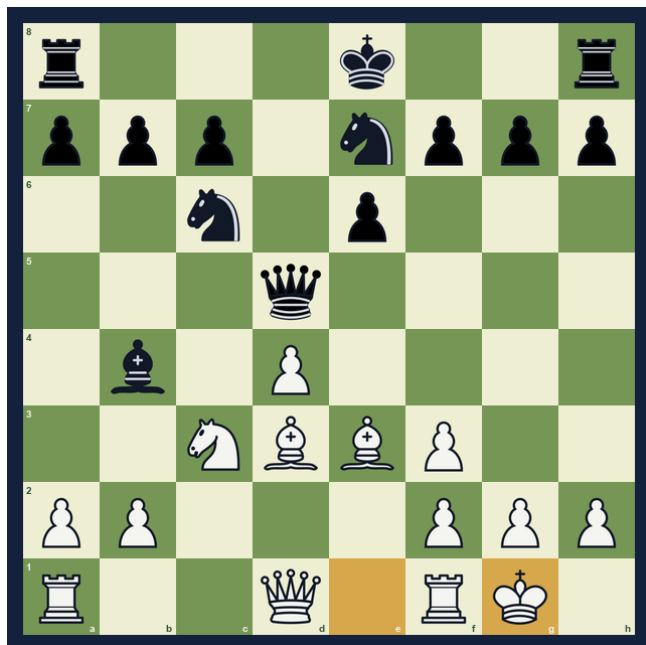
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

02. Chigorin Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Be3 and Nc3 to attack the queen naturally.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and prepares active exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

02. Decision Framework

Chigorin Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.
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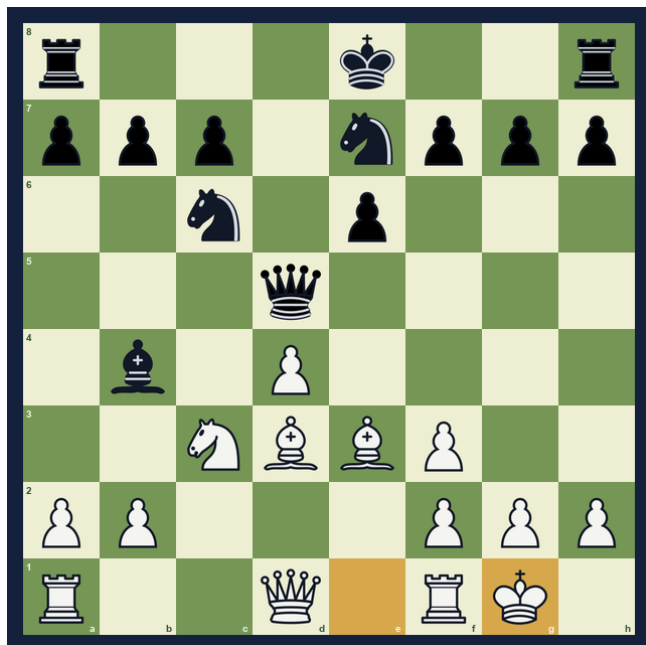
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03. Chigorin Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

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PRIMARY PLAN

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OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

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MEMORY RULE

Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

03. Decision Framework

Chigorin Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

04. Albin Countergambit



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Nbd2, and b4 to contain d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...d4: Black gains space and restricts c3 and e3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

MEMORY RULE

Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

04. Decision Framework

Albin Countergambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.
PIECE JOB	White's knights blockade d4 while the bishops develop around the advanced pawn without grabbing it prematurely.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the dangerous attacking pieces before collecting the pawn, especially when Black's queen and bishops point at the king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, blockade the wedge, remove tactical attackers, and only then convert the extra central pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

05. Albin Countergambit



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Nbd2, and b4 to contain d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...d4: Black gains space and restricts c3 and e3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

MEMORY RULE

Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

05. Decision Framework

Albin Countergambit

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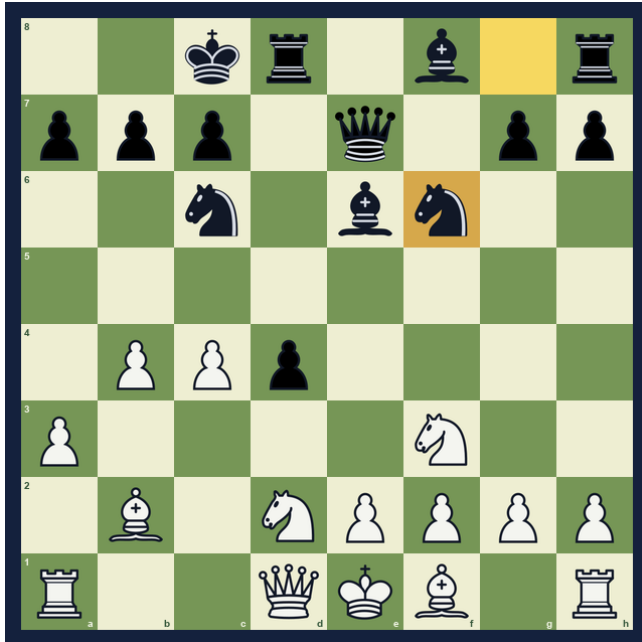
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

06. Albin Countergambit



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Nbd2, and b4 to contain d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...d4: Black gains space and restricts c3 and e3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

MEMORY RULE

Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

06. Decision Framework

Albin Countergambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.
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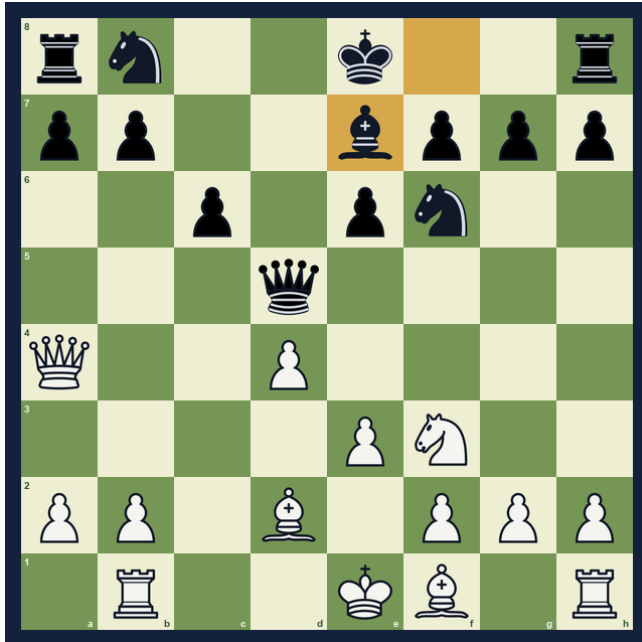
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

07. Baltic Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Bd2, and e3 against the queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bxb1: Black gives the bishop for a rook-tempo sequence.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

07. Decision Framework

Baltic Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ and the active bishops exploit Black's early bishop move while White develops with threats.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.
TRADE FILTER	Trade queens only when White's development or structural edge survives; otherwise keep the initiative against the exposed king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the gained tempos to mobilize every piece, then turn the lead into central pressure rather than chasing the bishop. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.

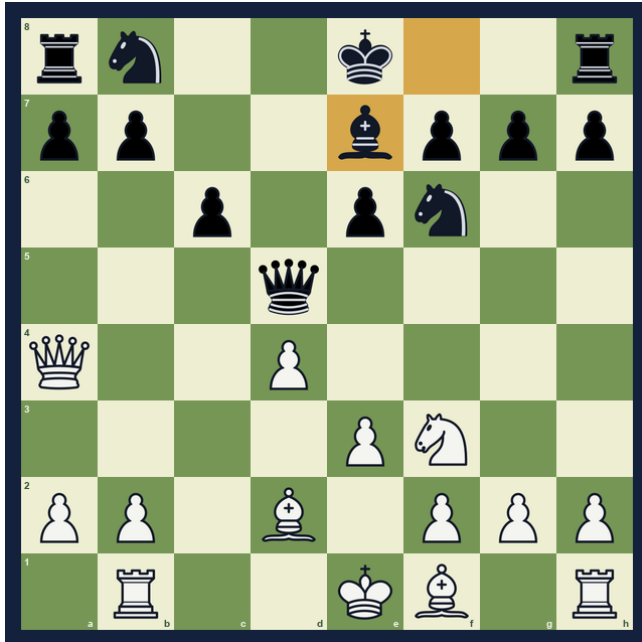
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

08. Baltic Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Bd2, and e3 against the queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bxb1: Black gives the bishop for a rook-tempo sequence.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

08. Decision Framework

Baltic Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ and the active bishops exploit Black's early bishop move while White develops with threats.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.
TRADE FILTER	Trade queens only when White's development or structural edge survives; otherwise keep the initiative against the exposed king.
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CLOCK RULE	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.

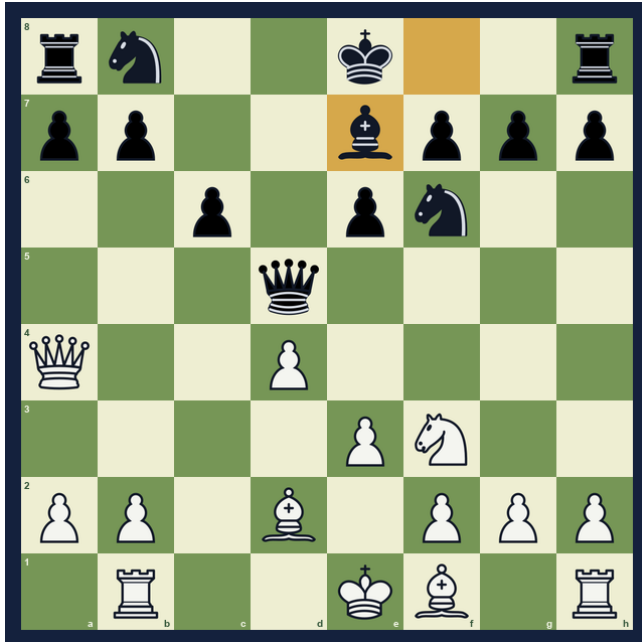
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

09. Baltic Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Bd2, and e3 against the queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bxb1: Black gives the bishop for a rook-tempo sequence.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

09. Decision Framework

Baltic Defense

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CLOCK RULE	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.

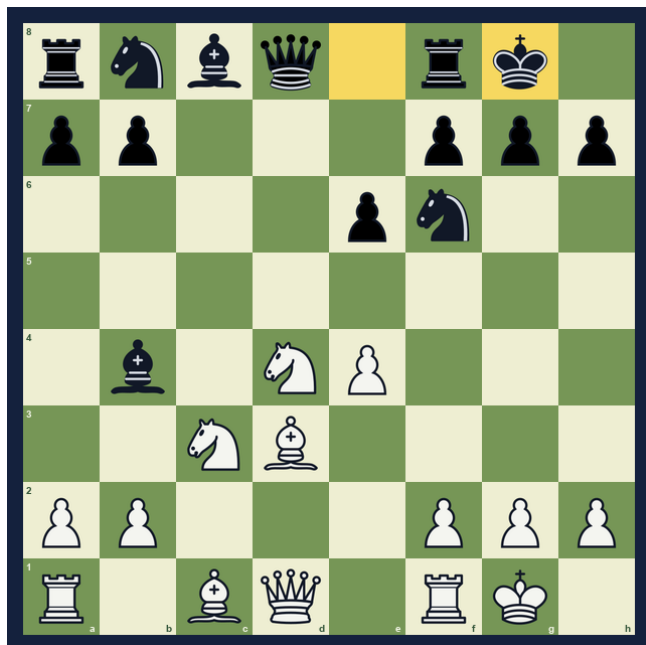
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

10. Marshall Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nc3, Bd3, and castling behind the center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nxd5: Black recovers the pawn with a knight but loses time.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. Nf3 e6 5. e4 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 c5 8. O-O cxd4 9. Nxd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Marshall: exchange d5, play e4, and turn the knight's lost time into development.

10. Decision Framework

Marshall Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawns and rapidly developed pieces should make the black knight's repeated moves visible on the board.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not keep attacking the knight if development is stronger.
TRADE FILTER	Keep active central pieces and exchange only when the resulting space or pawn gain remains after queens come off.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Build the center with tempo, castle and open lines before Black catches up in development. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not keep attacking the knight if development is stronger.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Marshall: exchange d5, play e4, and turn the knight's lost time into development.

11. Marshall Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

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PRIMARY PLAN

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OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

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REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. Nf3 e6 5. e4 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 c5 8. O-O cxd4 9. Nxd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Marshall: exchange d5, play e4, and turn the knight's lost time into development.

11. Decision Framework

Marshall Defense

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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

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12. Marshall Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

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MEMORY RULE

Marshall: exchange d5, play e4, and turn the knight's lost time into development.

12. Decision Framework

Marshall Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.
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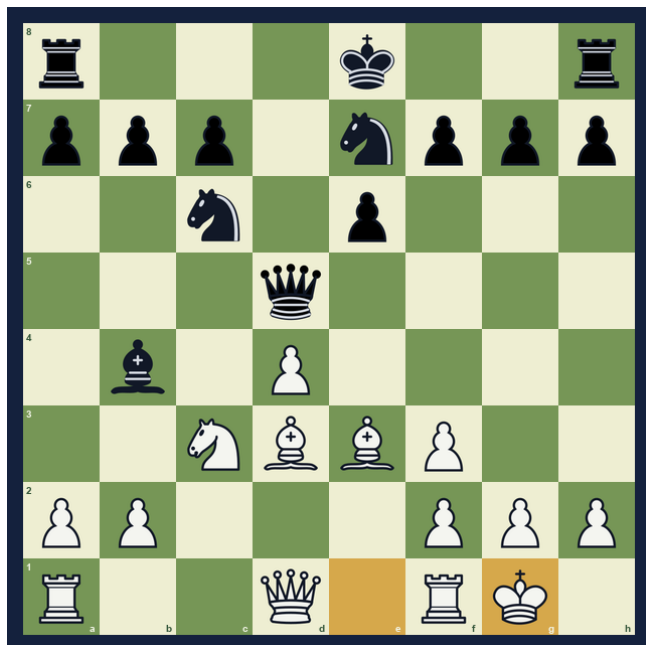
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Marshall: exchange d5, play e4, and turn the knight's lost time into development.

13. Chigorin Defense - Move-Order Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and prepares active exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

13. Decision Framework

Chigorin Defense - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.
PIECE JOB	The doubled f-pawns give White open lines and bishop activity, so pieces should use those assets rather than defend appearances.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active minor pieces when the bishop pair and open files remain; avoid exchanges that leave only the doubled pawns.
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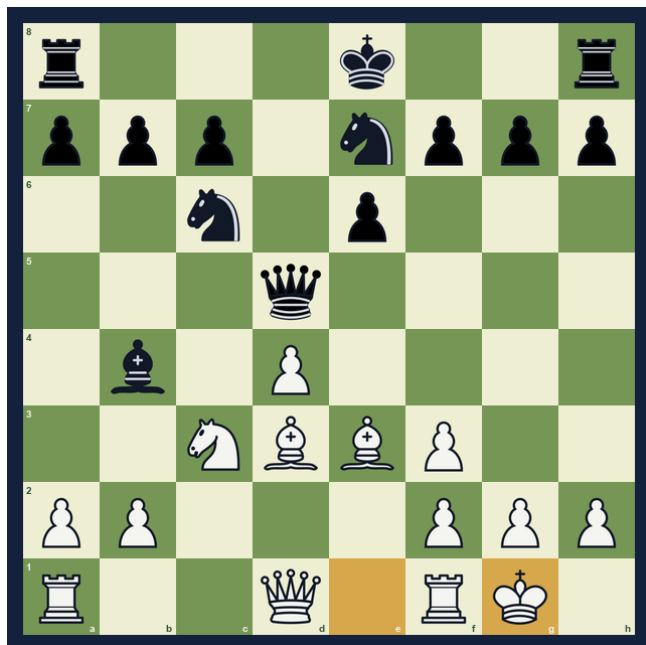
ACTIVE RECALL

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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

14. Chigorin Defense - Plan Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Use Be3 and Nc3 to attack the queen naturally.

PRIMARY PLAN

The doubled f-pawns give White open lines and bishop activity, so pieces should use those assets rather than defend appearances.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and prepares active exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

14. Decision Framework

Chigorin Defense - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.
PIECE JOB	The doubled f-pawns give White open lines and bishop activity, so pieces should use those assets rather than defend appearances.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active minor pieces when the bishop pair and open files remain; avoid exchanges that leave only the doubled pawns.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use bishops and open files to create threats, then simplify only after Black's activity has been neutralized. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.

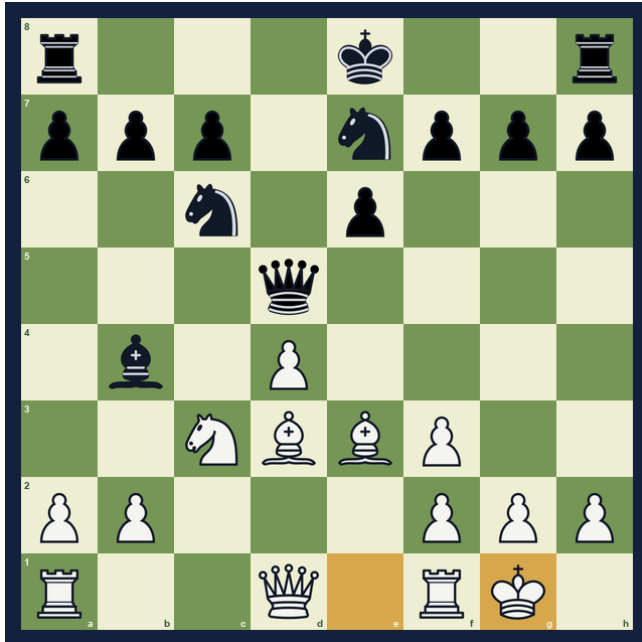
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

15. Chigorin Defense - Break Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and prepares active exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

15. Decision Framework

Chigorin Defense - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.
PIECE JOB	The doubled f-pawns give White open lines and bishop activity, so pieces should use those assets rather than defend appearances.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active minor pieces when the bishop pair and open files remain; avoid exchanges that leave only the doubled pawns.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use bishops and open files to create threats, then simplify only after Black's activity has been neutralized. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

16. Albin Countergambit - Trade Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Exchange the dangerous attacking pieces before collecting the pawn, especially when Black's queen and bishops point at the king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete development, blockade the wedge, remove tactical attackers, and only then convert the extra central pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...d4: Black gains space and restricts c3 and e3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

16. Decision Framework

Albin Countergambit - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.
PIECE JOB	White's knights blockade d4 while the bishops develop around the advanced pawn without grabbing it prematurely.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the dangerous attacking pieces before collecting the pawn, especially when Black's queen and bishops point at the king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, blockade the wedge, remove tactical attackers, and only then convert the extra central pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

17. Albin Countergambit - Move-Order Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...d4: Black gains space and restricts c3 and e3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

17. Decision Framework

Albin Countergambit - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.
PIECE JOB	White's knights blockade d4 while the bishops develop around the advanced pawn without grabbing it prematurely.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the dangerous attacking pieces before collecting the pawn, especially when Black's queen and bishops point at the king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, blockade the wedge, remove tactical attackers, and only then convert the extra central pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.

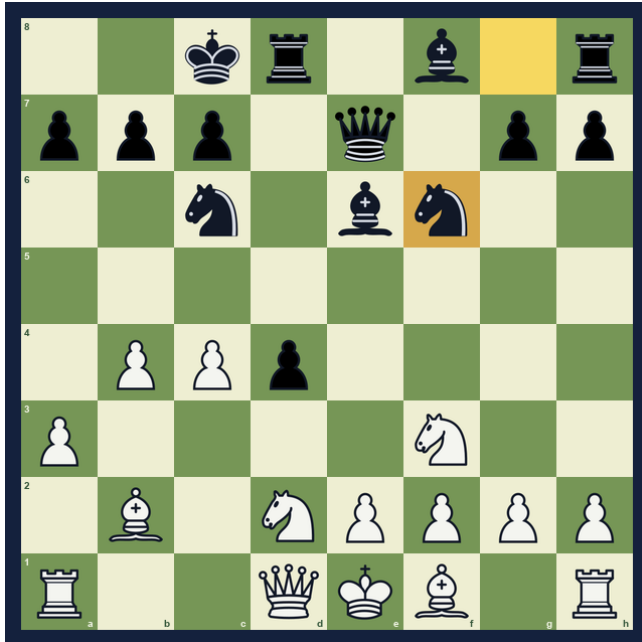
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

18. Albin Countergambit - Plan Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Use Nf3, Nbd2, and b4 to contain d4.

PRIMARY PLAN

White's knights blockade d4 while the bishops develop around the advanced pawn without grabbing it prematurely.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...d4: Black gains space and restricts c3 and e3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

18. Decision Framework

Albin Countergambit - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.
PIECE JOB	White's knights blockade d4 while the bishops develop around the advanced pawn without grabbing it prematurely.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the dangerous attacking pieces before collecting the pawn, especially when Black's queen and bishops point at the king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, blockade the wedge, remove tactical attackers, and only then convert the extra central pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.

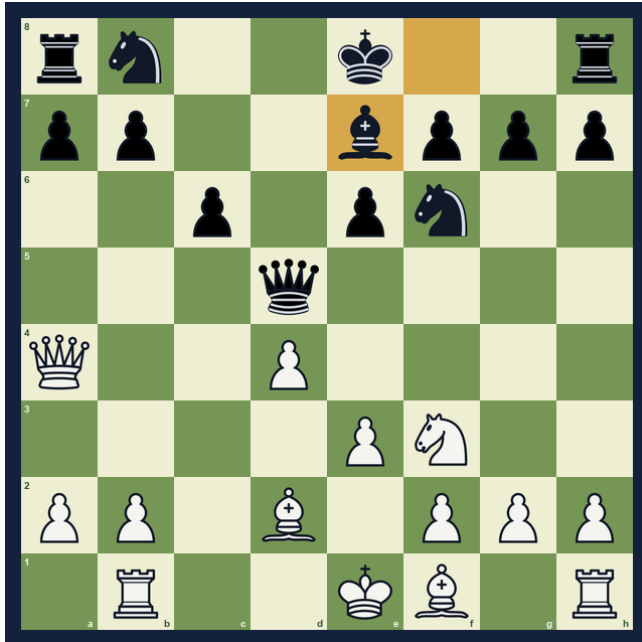
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

19. Baltic Defense - Break Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

PRIMARY PLAN

Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bxb1: Black gives the bishop for a rook-tempo sequence.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

19. Decision Framework

Baltic Defense - Break Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ and the active bishops exploit Black's early bishop move while White develops with threats.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.
TRADE FILTER	Trade queens only when White's development or structural edge survives; otherwise keep the initiative against the exposed king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the gained tempos to mobilize every piece, then turn the lead into central pressure rather than chasing the bishop. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.

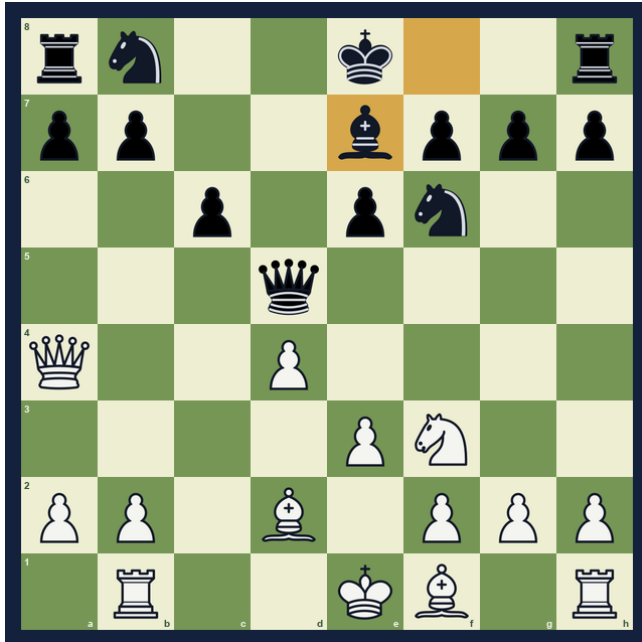
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the central break through the first quiet position.

20. Baltic Defense - Trade Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

READ THE POSITION

Trade queens only when White's development or structural edge survives; otherwise keep the initiative against the exposed king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the gained tempos to mobilize every piece, then turn the lead into central pressure rather than chasing the bishop. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bxb1: Black gives the bishop for a rook-tempo sequence.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

20. Decision Framework

Baltic Defense - Trade Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ and the active bishops exploit Black's early bishop move while White develops with threats.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.
TRADE FILTER	Trade queens only when White's development or structural edge survives; otherwise keep the initiative against the exposed king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the gained tempos to mobilize every piece, then turn the lead into central pressure rather than chasing the bishop. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Approve a trade only after describing the resulting structure and ending.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.